Newsom Signs Bill Limiting Ultra-Processed Foods in School Meals

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California has enacted the nation's first law defining and restricting ultra-processed foods in school meals, aiming to remove products linked to negative health effects from cafeterias across the state.

Gov. Gavin Newsom signed AB 1264, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D–San Fernando Valley), establishing a legal definition of ultra-processed foods and requiring schools to phase out the most concerning items over time.

Supporters say the new law is a response to growing research linking highly processed foods—such as those with artificial additives, preservatives, and sweeteners—to health and behavioral issues in children.

Assembly member Gabriel called the bill a "science-based" measure aimed at aligning school nutrition with public health standards. "California is once again leading the nation," he said in a statement.

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